

the start and took the lead. For nearly 18 laps, Verstappen managed to stay ahead.

But beneath the surface, it became apparent that the joy wouldn't last long for the home crowd. Norris and McLaren were on a different level, and it was a matter of when, not if, the British driver would reclaim the lead.

Just as Verstappen started complaining on the radio that he didn't have the grip to post quick times, Norris passed the defending champion on lap 18 to take the lead.

From there on, Norris unleashed the pace of the McLaren and sailed into the distance, finishing a commanding 22 seconds ahead of Verstappen to clinch his second career victory. It was McLaren's third win of the season, and the orange-coloured cars cut Red Bull's lead in the constructors' standings by 12 points. It could have been even better for McLaren had Oscar Piastri managed to get onto the podium, but he was thwarted by a resolute Charles Leclerc, who kept the faster McLaren at bay in the final third of the race. Piastri, like Norris, lost out at the start, slipping one place to fourth and ending up fifth after his pit stop. While he quickly passed George Russell's Mercedes, the Australian struggled to get past Leclerc's Ferrari despite having nine laps fresher tires.

Nevertheless, with McLaren trailing by just 30 points, the team now looks like the odds-on favourite for the constructors' title if the form book continues for the rest of the season.

Code red at Red Bull

While Verstappen still managed to finish second, the margin of defeat to Norris, despite leading for nearly 18 laps, should worry the

reigning champion. For the Dutchman, it was a case of minimising the damage, and he came out of this round still 70 points ahead of Norris. Despite the handy lead, the 26-year-old now faces a real threat to his crown. All it might take is one or two non-finishes from Verstappen, and the driver's title race will come alive. The alarm bells are ringing at Red Bull as the team looks completely lost in the developmental race. It even returned to an older-spec floor on Verstappen's car, which was used in the first race of the year in Bahrain, indicating that Red Bull's new parts aren't working at all. The fact that Sergio Perez had a decent outing and still finished only sixth behind both the McLarens and the Ferraris laid bare the outfit's struggles.

It has been a tumultuous year for Red Bull despite its brilliant on-track performance at the start of the season. The year began with harassment charges against team boss Christian Horner by a female employee. Though Horner was cleared of the charges, the incident exposed the internal power struggle between Horner and Dr. Helmut Marko, the head of Red Bull's young driver's programme. The team then lost Adrian Newey, the greatest F1 designer and the architect of all its championships. Earlier this month, another key member, Jonathan Wheatley, the Sporting Director, resigned. Wheatley had been at Red Bull since 2006 and ensured the team's track operations on race day were inch-perfect, making the team sharp on strategies and pit stops.

At a time when the team's on-track performance has nosedived, these upheavals portend a worrying time for the energy drink giant.

AFP



MotoGP



Meanwhile, in the world of two-wheeler racing, two-time reigning champion Francesco Bagnaia (**above, front**) regained the lead in the championship after a stunning performance at the Red Bull Ring in Austria. Riding his factory Ducati, the Italian rider did the double, winning both the Sprint and Grand Prix to open up a five-point lead over rival Jorge Martin (**behind**) of the Prima Pramac Racing customer Ducati. It was an important weekend for Bagnaia after Martin's performance in the British GP had put him ahead in the standings. Bagnaia was unbeatable all weekend and cruised to victory, significantly boosting his title hopes. The 27-year-old will want to seal a hat-trick of crowns this year before six-time MotoGP champion Marc Marquez joins him as a teammate in 2025. A title loss to Martin on the customer Ducati would be a massive blow to Bagnaia's reputation, something he will look to avoid.